looked a different man altogether'. The change was so great that 'all those who met Bhagat Singh then and afterwards have testified to his remarkable intelligence and to the powerful impression he made when talking'. Now 'he spoke with force, passion and earnestness' and 'we talked the whole night' and 'it seemed to me that a new era was dawning for our party'.[4]

How did this happen? The veteran distinguished lawyer and writer A.G. Noorani notes how 'in a real sense, Bhagat Singh's intellectual life properly began only when he entered prison' because although 'he had, of course, read avidly before', the reality was that 'the activist had little time for intellectual pursuits'.[5] This suggests that the date of Bhagat Singh's arrest on 8 April 1929 is the watershed moment in his life. It is what intellectualizes him as a new revolutionary force in India. This is confirmed by Shiv Verma, who was in Lahore Central Jail with him and attests to how 'we had easy access to books in jail since day one and the atmosphere was quite congenial for study and exchange of ideas'. Further, 'we used to discuss ideological and social issues earlier too, but Bhagat Singh's arrival made this much more lively'. As a result, 'seldom a day would pass without having thrashed out an issue threadbare'. He continues, 'The books which had been read during the week, were on diverse topics as Marxism, progress in Soviet Russia, upsurge in Afghanistan, Sino-Japanese strife, League of Nations' fiasco, the Meerut Conspiracy Case, Labour struggle, role of Indian capitalist class, policy of the Congress and possibility of a change in political goal in Lahore Congress session.' One cannot help wonder at this how different India would have been today if, instead of being annihilated as a political force, this emerging class of self-taught intellectuals had been allowed to take their rightful place at the heart of government. For it is a mistake to think that Bhagat Singh alone was interested in honing his intellectual and political acumen. Others were too. But as Shiv Verma explained, 'though we all had a passion for reading, but (*sic*) Bhagat Singh was a class by himself'.[6] Another inmate, incarcerated with Bhagat Singh, Jatinder Nath Sanyal, also vouched for his being an 'extremely well-read man' but 'the economic experiment in Russia under the Bolshevik regime greatly interested him'. This is reflected in his taking